Songs from an Island

By Ingeborg Bachmann

INTRODUCTION

Pliny the Younger's accounts of the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in 79 AD, tell a grim but detailed tale of destruction. . . . "We saw the sea sucked away and apparently forced back by the earthquake: at any rate it receded from the shore so that quantities of sea creatures were left stranded on dry sand. On the landward side a fearful black cloud was rent by forked and quivering bursts of flame, and parted to reveal great tongues of fire, like flashes of lightning magnified in size. . . . We had scarcely sat down to rest when darkness fell, not the dark of a moonless or cloudy night, but as if the lamp had been put out in a closed room. You could hear the shrieks of women, the wailing of infants, and the shouting of men; some were calling their parents, others their children or their wives, trying to recognize them by their voices. People bewailed their own fate or that of their relatives, and there were some who prayed for death in their terror of dying." Centuries later Ingeborg Bachmann commemorates the power of nature and predicts future turmoil in her tribute titled Songs from an Island.

Shadow fruit is falling from the walls,

moonlight bathes the house in white, and the ash

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of extinct craters is borne in by the sea wind.

In the embrace of handsome youths

the coasts are sleeping.

Your flesh remembers mine,

it was already inclined to me,

when the ships

loosened themselves from shore and the cross

of our mortal burden

kept watch in the rigging.

Now the execution sites are empty,

they search but cannot find us.

When you rise from the dead,

when I rise from the dead,

no stone will lie before the gate,

no boat will rest on the sea.

Tomorrow the casks will roll

toward Sunday waves,

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we come on anointed

soles to the shore, wash
the grapes and stamp
the harvest into wine,
tomorrow, on the shore.

When you rise from the dead,
when I rise from the dead,
the hangman will hang at the gate,
the hammer will sink into the sea.

One day the feast must come!
Saint Anthony, you who have suffered,
Saint Leonard, you who have suffered,
Saint Vitus, you who have suffered.

Make way for our prayers, way for the worshippers,
room for music and joy!
We have learned simplicity,
we sing in the choir of cicadas,

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we eat and drink,
the lean cats
rub against our table,
until evening mass begins
I hold your hand
with my eyes,
and a quiet, brave heart
sacrifices its wishes to you

Honey and nuts for the children,
teeming nets for the fishermen,
fertility for the gardens,
moon for the volcano, moon for the volcano!

Our sparks leapt over the borders,
above the night fireworks fanned their
tails, the procession
floats away on dark rafts and gives
time to the primeval world,
to the plodding lizards,
to the carnivorous plant,

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to the feverish fish,
to the orgies of wind and the lust
of mountains where a pious
star loses its way, collides with their face
and dissolves into dust.

Stand firm, you foolish saints.
Tell the mainland the craters aren't resting!
Saint Roch, you who have suffered,
oh you who have suffered, Saint Francis.

When someone departs he must throw his hat,
filled with the mussels he spent the summer
gathering, in the sea
and sail off with his hair in the wind,
he must hurl the table,
set for his love, in the sea,
he must pour the wine,
left in his glass, into the sea,
he must give his bread to the fish
and mix a drop of his blood with the sea,

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he must drive his knife deep into the waves
and sink his shoes,
heart, anchor and cross,
and sail off with his hair in the wind.
Then he will return.
When?
Do not ask.

There is fire under the earth,
and the fire is pure.

There is fire under the earth
and molten rock.

There is a torrent under the earth,
it will stream into us.

There is a torrent under the earth.
it will scorch our bones.

A great fire is coming,

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a torrent is coming over the earth.

We shall be witnesses.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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